



VOLCANOES

Volcanic eruptions and earthquakes are a frequent part of life in this region. They are caused by the movement of huge pieces of the Earth's crust, called tectonic plates. Much of maritime Southeast Asia lies over a massive arc-shaped join between two of these plates. Despite the terrible destruction that eruptions cause, the islanders risk growing crops on the slopes of active volcanoes because their ash makes the soil fertile.

This Australasian Komodo dragon lives on an island to the east of Wallace's Line.



NATURAL VARIETY

During the 1850s the British naturalist Alfred Russel Wallace journeyed through these islands. He noticed that most of the animals on the island of Bali were Asian in origin, but those on neighboring Lombok were mainly Australasian. "Wallace's Line" is an imaginary line drawn across the region to divide the islands with Asian animals from those with Australasian animals.



Islands to the west of Wallace's Line are filled with Asian animals, such as this orangutan.



TSUNAMI 2004

On December 26, 2004, a massive underwater earthquake off the northwest coast of Sumatra created a giant wave, known as a tsunami, that quickly rippled out across the Indian Ocean. The tsunami was so powerful that it killed at least 225,000 people in 11 nations, including 170,000 in Indonesia. Coastal towns, such as the port of Banda Aceh (shown above) were decimated, while people were killed as far away as Somalia on the east coast of Africa.



Scientists studying the rain forests in this region have discovered that they contain one-sixth of all the world's bird species.

THE TROPICAL RAIN FORESTS

Individual islands provide different natural habitats, so the animals and plants that have evolved on one island may be very different to those on the next. This means that the region's dense rain forests contain the greatest variety of species in the world. This is why it is so vital that these forests should be protected and not cut down or cleared.

THE RAFFLESIA FLOWER

This rare plant, found deep in the rain forests, is named after Sir Stamford Raffles, a British governor in this region during the 19th century. It has the world's largest flowers, measuring up to 3 ft (91 cm) across. *Rafflesia* is famous for its foul smell, which attracts insects.

